



TokyoExpat

YOUR JAPAN RELOCATION EXPERTS

2026 FOREIGNER'S GUIDE

Finding an **Apartment** in Tokyo as a Foreigner

How the Tokyo rental market works, which agencies to use, what documents you need, and the red flags to avoid.

2-3x

Deposit months typically required
upfront

~30%

Of Tokyo landlords reject foreign
applicants

2-4

Weeks from search to move-in
(typical)

CHAPTER 1



Understanding the Tokyo Rental Market

WHAT IS KEY MONEY (礼金 / REIKIN)?

A non-refundable "thank you" payment

Paid to the landlord at signing. Usually 1-2 months rent. Increasingly rare in Tokyo (ask your agent for "reikin zero" listings). Not a scam: it is standard in Japan.

WHAT IS DEPOSIT (敷金 / SHIKIKIN)?

A refundable security deposit

Usually 1-2 months rent. Refunded at end of tenancy minus cleaning and repair costs. Always document pre-existing damage with photos on move-in day.

AGENCY FEE (仲介手数料)

One month rent (usually)

Paid to the real estate agency, not the landlord. Legally capped at 1 month rent + tax. Some agencies charge 0 on tenant side (landlord pays). Ask upfront.

GUARANTOR (保証人 / HOSHOUNIN)

Your biggest challenge as a foreigner

Most landlords require a Japanese guarantor OR a paid guarantee company (hoshougaisha). Budget ~0.5-1 month rent/year for the guarantee company fee.

CHAPTER 2



Neighborhoods by Budget (2026)

Area	1K/Studio (monthly)	1LDK (monthly)	Best for
Adachi, Katsushika, Edogawa	50,000-75,000 JPY	80,000-110,000 JPY	Budget-conscious, families, students
Koto, Sumida, Arakawa	65,000-90,000 JPY	90,000-130,000 JPY	Great transit, newer buildings
Shinjuku, Nakameguro, Meguro	90,000-140,000 JPY	130,000-200,000 JPY	Lifestyle, nightlife, international community
Shibuya, Minato, Chiyoda	120,000-200,000 JPY	180,000-350,000 JPY	Corporate expats, prestige address
Setagaya, Nerima	75,000-110,000 JPY	110,000-160,000 JPY	Families, quiet residential, good schools

Tip: The "5-min walk to station" rule matters enormously for resale and rental value in Tokyo. Every extra minute of walking distance reduces rent by ~2-3%. Stay within 8 minutes walk.

CHAPTER 3



Foreigner-Friendly Agencies and Platforms

FOREIGNER-FRIENDLY

Sakura House

Share houses and private rooms. English-only OK. No guarantor, no key money. 50,000-120,000 JPY. Best for new arrivals with no documents yet.

FOREIGNER-FRIENDLY

Oakhouse

Share houses across Tokyo. Monthly contracts available. No Japanese required. English staff. Also private apartments in some locations.

BILINGUAL AGENCY

Plaza Homes

Full-service bilingual real estate agency. Specializes in expat clients. Higher-end inventory. Good for 1LDK+ listings. realestate-tokyo.com.

ONLINE PLATFORM

Housing Japan

English-language listings aggregator. Bilingual agents. Many listings explicitly marked "foreigners welcome" (外国人可). housingjapan.com.

JAPANESE PLATFORM

SUUMO + AtHome

Japan's largest portals. Look for 外国人可 (foreigners welcome) filter. Requires Japanese or a bilingual agent to contact landlords.

MONTHLY FURNISHED

WeXpats Housing

English-language platform for foreigners. Mix of share houses, monthly apartments, long-term. weXpats.com/en/house.

CHAPTER 4



The Application Process — Step by Step

- 1 Gather your documents before you start looking**
Residence Card, passport, bank statement (3 months), employment contract or proof of income, My Number Card (if available). Having these ready speeds up the process by 1-2 weeks.
- 2 Book a property viewing (naiken)**
Same-day viewings are common in Japan. Bring your Residence Card. The agent will show 2-4 properties in a single visit. Take photos and videos.
- 3 Submit your application (moushikomi)**
You submit a form with your name, employer, income, and a reference. Landlord has 2-5 business days to approve or reject. Foreigners: ~30% rejection rate.
- 4 Sign the lease agreement (chinshaku keiyaku)**
In Japanese. Ask for English translation or use DeepL. Key clauses: renewal terms, early termination fee (usually 2 months rent), renovation responsibility.
- 5 Pay initial costs and receive keys**
Total upfront: 3-5 months rent equivalent (deposit + key money + agency fee + first month). Bank transfer required. Keys on move-in day.

CHAPTER 5



Red Flags to Avoid



Agency pushing you to decide same day

Good apartments move fast, but no legitimate agency forces a 2-hour decision. High-pressure tactics suggest unsellable inventory or a weak application.



Reikin over 2 months

Key money above 2 months is unusual in central Tokyo (2026). More than that: walk away or negotiate hard. It is legally uncapped but practically limited by market norms.



No viewing allowed before signing

Always do an in-person naiken. Photos can hide mold, noise from traffic/trains, narrow rooms, or missing windows. This is especially common in low-price listings.



Monthly rent significantly below market average for the area

Below-average prices often hide: noise from major roads, proximity to industrial zones, a history of incidents (jiko bukken), or serious structural issues.



"Gaijin house" with management deposit

Some informal foreigner-targeted rentals ask for a deposit held by an individual (not a company). No paper trail, no legal protection. Avoid.

CHAPTER 6



Total Upfront Cost Calculator

Cost Item	50,000 JPY/mo rent	100,000 JPY/mo rent	150,000 JPY/mo rent
Deposit (2 months)	100,000	200,000	300,000
Key money (1 month)	50,000	100,000	150,000
Agency fee (1 month + tax)	55,000	110,000	165,000
Guarantee company fee (~0.7 mo)	35,000	70,000	105,000
First month rent	50,000	100,000	150,000
Total upfront	290,000 JPY	580,000 JPY	870,000 JPY

Move-in day checklist

- ☐ Photograph every room before unpacking
- ☐ Document all scratches, marks, stains
- ☐ Test all appliances, taps, windows
- ☐ Check electricity breaker box
- ☐ Confirm gas switch-on appointment
- ☐ Get WiFi password from landlord

After move-in: admin

- ☐ Update address at ward office (14 days)
- ☐ Update Residence Card address
- ☐ Notify bank, NHI, pension
- ☐ Set up TEPCO electricity
- ☐ Book Tokyo Gas installation
- ☐ Order internet connection

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Your guide to life in Japan

Still have questions?

Every situation is different. Book a 1-on-1 consultation to get advice tailored to your visa, budget, and timeline — from someone who lives in Tokyo.

[Book a consultation](#)

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